

There's a Woman in Chicago:

Welfare Queen & The Story of America's Hatred of Poor Black Mothers

1980's Los Angeles was the place to be if you were a young actress looking to break into the professional wrestling industry. *GLOW: Gorgeous Ladies of Wrestling* was a women's wrestling promotion that brought combat, comedy, an occasional rap interlude, and the shameless personification of American stereotypes to millions of living rooms across the nation. In *GLOW*, you were either a "good girl" or a "bad girl." Among the ranks of the good girls, were Mt. Fiji, Tina the Southern Belle, and Americana, but the bad girls were a lot more interesting. Some of the more notable characters were Major Tanya, the America hating Bolshevik from Kiev, Russia (at the time) with a hammer and sickle tattoo and Palestina, the "Twisted Terrorist" from Damascus, Syria who would stop mid-match for her prayer ritual. However, Lynn Braxton's character Big Bad Mama (A.K.A. The Voodoo Queen) was one of the more outwardly problematic. Opening each match with a large plastic bone and voodoo doll in hand, Big Bad Mama is said to weigh in at over 350 pounds, one announcer noting "I thought she only moved that fast when dinner was served." Many of the quips made toward The Voodoo Queen had to do with her laziness, loud demeanor, and, of course, her own commentary frequently featured the use of AAVE.¹

It's no wonder that when the story was adapted into a Netflix series, many viewers saw eerie similarities between Big Bad Mama and the character Black Magic. Others noticed a potential connection to Tamme "The Welfare Queen" Dawson.² Portrayed as a big angry black woman, who took down her opponents with food stamps, Welfare Queen couldn't seem to understand why people would go to work everyday when she just lets the United States Government pay for everything. In actuality, Tamme Dawson, the woman behind the character,

was a single mother trying to put her son through Stanford Medical School, forced to sacrifice her dignity and her son's respect in the process. It's a classic case of a Black American mother doing what every other mother does but getting villainized for it by the media and conservative political machines.^{3,4}

Since slavery, Black women in America have been subjugated to an onslaught of sexist stereotypes effectively characterizing their humanity as either the hyper-aggressive *Sapphire* –a.k.a. *Angry Black Woman*–, or the hyper-sexual *Jezebel* from films like *Black Hooker*, or the hyper-maternal *Mammy* first seen as the O'Haras devoted house slave in *Gone With the Wind*.⁵ However, in March of 1965, member of the Johnson Administration Daniel Patrick Moynihan published a report that combined characteristics of the three to create a newer political trope: The Black Matriarch. Though well intentioned, this report would unwittingly facilitate the cultural, political, and economic scrutinization of Black mothers by laying the groundwork for one of the most economically offensive stereotypes in American History regarding Black women, the hyper-neglectful and criminally lazy Welfare Queen.⁶

Before the Welfare Queen

Unsurprisingly, modern preconceptions surrounding the Black family and Black Motherhood date back to slavery. Due to systemic conditions, largely white supremacy, the Black family structure was incredibly weak and lacked institutional support, noting that “during slavery, the government condoned and/or promoted a system in which marriage and family among slaves had no legal status. Slave parents had no recognized authority over the children to whom they gave birth; slave children were subject to sale by their owners.” Slave-owners took advantage of families for their own legal and economic interests: conceiving children with enslaved women so they could own their children or using fear of family separation to

discourage disobedience or rebellion. The “white male sexual exploitation of female slaves, and the breakup of slave families by the sale of the husband and father” in addition to harsh economic conditions for former slaves during the reconstruction and post-reconstruction eras, has resulted in an America that has always been hostile toward Black families.⁷

Over time, conservative politicians would use this perceived instability of the Black family to advocate against state and federal welfare policies. In 1935, the Social Security Act instituted the Aid to Dependent Children federal welfare program, which mainly served White women who were widowed or deserted. The main objective was to allow women to maintain a homemaker role in their families even when bereft of financial support from a male figure. Further, assistance for Black women has been severely limited.⁸ Throughout the 1940s and 50s, regulations including “employable mother” and “man-in-the-house” laws, served as the basis for denying enrollment to Black women in high density African American areas. Many states in the south outright banned Black women from receiving state income assistance due to political desires to keep them in the workforce. These regulations also helped quell public anxiety about high costs and widespread dependency. This is just one example of how New Deal Era programs excluded Black families from economic benefits.⁹

By the 1960s, President Lyndon B. Johnson had declared a War on Poverty that brought about the expansion and liberalization of state assistance: “the Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC) program in 1967 and then into the Transitional Aid to Needy Families (TANF) program in 1996,”¹⁰ whereas court cases like *Goldberg vs. Kelly* ruled that due process was required before suspending a family’s welfare access and “man-in-the-house” laws were thrown out as unconstitutional.¹¹ However, while access expanded, hostility brewed as well. In 1965, Johnson commissioned the Moynihan Report which aimed to illustrate the ways in which

institutions had failed Black families; although, what most people took away from the report –and what Moynihan himself championed– was that the single-motherhood and the breakdown of Black families were to blame for the social and economic inequalities between Black and White Americans. This was also one of the first times that the term “Welfare lady” would be used to describe Black single-mothers receiving state or federal assistance.¹² As the TANF’s size grew, and costs subsequently increased, the stigmatization of Black motherhood became central to conservative political conversations. Fears also arose that “the increasing number of ‘welfare babies’ would ‘breed more criminals, more mental defectives, more unemployables of almost every type.’”¹³ Stigmatization of welfare crept into popular culture with songs like “Welfare Cadillac” by Guy Drake in 1970, depicting a family that lived in “a dilapidated, neglected house” while driving around in a new tax-payer sponsored Cadillac.

The Birth of the Welfare Queen

Fraud investigations became a common strategy that states used to “trim the welfare rolls” like requiring recipients to pick up their checks at police stations and mainly targeted African American communities. Senators like Robert Byrd would often critique social workers who did not impose hefty burdens on welfare recipients as being tolerant of fraud. From the late 1960s and throughout the 1970s, states like Illinois would lead the charge in investigating and prosecuting “welfare fraud.” They hired fraud investigators and instituted home visits among a myriad of other initiatives that did succeed in eventually stabilizing the welfare caseload. Politicians like Senator Newhouse and Jesse Jackson responded to the anti-fraud initiatives by calling out how these anti-fraud campaigns cost more to the taxpayer than the fraud itself and targeted poor people while ignoring corporate theft.¹⁴

The most famous case of Linda Taylor made its way to headlines throughout the nation. Taylor “was charged with defrauding Illinois welfare programs by collecting welfare cash grants, social security and food stamps under multiple aliases.” Though the state was only able to prove the defrauding of \$8,000 and four aliases in total, media outlets made sure to dig into her deceptive character and make absurd claims from having 100 aliases, 31 addresses, and 3 cars to claiming benefits as several different races thanks to their disguise of her 30 wigs to kidnapping and impersonating a voodoo doctor. The Chicago Tribune was the first to crown Taylor as *The Welfare Queen*.¹⁵ While Taylor and other women convicted of welfare fraud, often referred to as “The Original Welfare Queens,” were extreme outliers, politicians like Ronald Reagan were quick to characterize the modal AFDC recipient as “lazy, sexually promiscuous (typically African American) women who shirk both domestic and wage labor.”¹⁶

“There’s a woman in Chicago,” Reagan would open his campaign speeches during his 1974 presidential bid. Sometimes “The Woman in Chicago” had 80 names, 30 addresses, and 12 social security cards. Sometimes, she raked in over \$150,000 in tax-free annual income as a result of her deception toward the state. Everytime, the story was different. But, by employing preconceptions of Black economic behavior that arose in the context of the Moynihan Report, and using the word *queen* which has derogatory racial, gender, and class subtext, Reagan never had to mention race. Everyone knew what color the Welfare Queen was, and Reagan was king of the Welfare Queen.¹⁷

The Welfare Queen epithet would go on to help Reagan win his 1980 presidential bid four years later and helped him build support for the Family Support Act in the late 1970s, making work requirements an AFDC regulation. After reaching near hegemonic status in the 1980s and 1990s, the Welfare Queen was employed by Newt Gingrich and other conservative

politicians to tear apart AFDC altogether and replace it with Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF), a more restrictive and punitive form of public assistance.¹⁸ The Welfare Queen also popped up when Bill Clinton campaigned to “end welfare as we know it” and then proceeded to live up to that promise with the passage of the 1996 helped Bill Clinton pass the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Act.¹⁹

Historically, the Welfare Queen has been and continues to be a caricature of Black, unwed, and neglectful mothers. She is promiscuous, overweight, “ghetto”, and lazy.²⁰ The ultimate threat to American White society, she poses a financial burden and has bad morals that she will pass down to the many children she irresponsibly conceives. In reality, the woman the Welfare Queen represents threatens social order because she rejects “the nuclear family as a bedrock social institution.” The Welfare Queen capitalizes on economic fears to unite voters against immigration as well. Many right-wing leaders have extended the phrase to first generation Asian and Latino Mothers. They describe their babies as “anchor babies” and accuse them of taking handouts and draining the country’s coveted economic and social resources. In effect, the Welfare Queen distracts from the American Government’s failure to responsibly address the struggles of the working poor and the lack of mobility for Black families. The rich politicians turn the frustrations of the working poor against the frustrations of the non-working poor while their economic status evades the debate altogether.²¹

Welfare Queen in the Laziness Dialogue

Poverty is the crime of Black women and the charge is *laziness*. The Welfare Queen is symptomatic of the racialization and criminalization of laziness. ‘Welfare Queen’ as a code word falls under the category of the Laziness implication along with other coded phrases like “Work Ethic” “Unemployed” “Leech” “Social Parasite.” Laziness as a derogatory term is heavily rooted

in Christianity. Christianity and Protestants especially ingrained laziness repulsion by emphasizing *sloth* as one of The Seven Deadly Sins and idleness as being devil-like or a tool of the devil. Hard work, in contrast, was praised as most righteous.²² This has been exemplified both in Max Weber's *Protestant Work Ethic and The Spirit of Capitalism* where he discusses how hard work has been viewed by Protestants as the path to salvation since the reformation and has spread to surrounding culture as well. As a result, laziness, the antithesis of hard work, provokes negative sentiment not just in Protestant cultures but cultures that have been touched by Protestantism as well (almost all of them).²³ Back in Colonial Virginia, Vagrancy Laws, which criminalized poverty, rested upon the stigma against laziness. They logicized that poverty was a result of laziness, and laziness, like crime, was "immoral and anti-social." In 1877, the Charity Organization Society, went as far to categorize unemployment and poverty as a disease where hyper-sexuality and laziness were the root causes. Ironically, this sentiment came as the country was coming out of an economic depression. Christianity and colonialism also worked together in the Puritan societies of Colonial America: the destitute were disregarded as lazy and immoral as "poverty indicated a lack of God's grace."²⁴

The Christian sin of laziness would evolve into capitalist sin during the Industrial Revolution. Laziness was a threat to productivity. Those who were not working, would be accused of being 'idle' or 'lazy'.²⁵ As the sin of laziness was secularized, there grew a fine line between the 'deserving' and 'undeserving' poor in America. The undeserving poor were typically children, widows, or had disabilities, while the deserving poor were able to work but did not. When it came to single mothers, the line was often drawn at the color of the mother.²⁶ While White single mothers often received empathy and understanding, Black and Brown mothers carried the burden of a public presumption of their hypersexuality, immorality, and

laziness. The Welfare Queen was the synecdoche for the single mother responsible for their own misfortune.²⁷ That is how politicians throughout the late-twentieth century were able to mobilize the public against welfare funding. Welfare is associated with Blackness, Blackness is associated with laziness. If you make it Black, you make it undeserving.²⁸

The Racialization and Criminalization of Laziness

The association of Blackness and laziness has been ingrained in American society since slavery. Those who upheld the system of slavery, confederate politicians and plantation owners, argued that slaves were inherently lazy and needed to be put to work. At the same time, Northerners rationalized Southern unproductivity overall.²⁹ With such racialization comes criminalization. If crime is the sin of Black men, state-dependence and single motherhood are the sins of Black women. One notorious example is in 1999, when the state of New York coerced welfare recipients into collecting trash along New York highways, working for \$1.10 an hour and sporting orange jumpsuits. Julie Kohler-Huasmann explains how this “forced onto women’s bodies a graphic link to criminality that had circled them rhetorically for decades” in turn capitalizing on the widely held notion that welfare recipients are innately lazy.³⁰ Criminality was the slavery loophole for Black men, and by essentially criminalizing receiving state assistance, a white supremacist state built that same loophole for Black women.

As a logical next step, the United States Government used the criminalization of Black women to justify surveillance and control. Similar to the use of excessive policing tactics to control Black men, new welfare regulations were the policing mechanism of Black women. In *Sanchez v. County of San Diego*, those applying for assistance under the California Work Opportunity and Responsibility to Kids Program were required to agree to a home visit where the details of such visits included extensive privacy breaches like closet and trash inspection.

However, the Ninth Circuit saw these visits as purely administrative and were thus not protected by the Fourth Amendment “unreasonable searches and seizures.” Clinton's 1996 Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity act instituted surveillance of “education, employment, drug consumption, and even sexuality.” The presumption of criminality ushered in new opportunities for the state surveillance of Black women.³¹

The War on Crime became a “War on People who Committed Acts that Were Criminalized,” and the War on Drugs became a “War on People who Did Drugs.” A story of the defeminization and villainization of poor, black women, the rise of the *Welfare Queen* as a hegemonic political construct serves as a harbinger of how the War on Poverty became a “War on Impoverished People.”

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